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ON VALUING WOMEN: ADVANCING AN INTERSECTIONAL THEORY OF GENDER DIVERSITY IN ORGANIZATIONS

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In recent years, a proliferation of research has supported the "business case" for diversity, in which scholars collect empirical data to demonstrate a relationship between the demographics of employees and organizational financial performance. However, the business case is only one way—and, we argue, the wrong way—of valuing the presence of women in business. In this manuscript, we focus on gender lens impact investing to interrogate the epistemic assumptions underlying the business case for diversity, and suggest that these assumptions have the potential to strengthen the very power structures that have historically excluded and marginalized many women. We then present an alternative: an intersectional theory of gender diversity. We argue that intersectionality requires diversity initiatives in organizations to include both the recognition of the interactions of multiple forms of identity and marginalization and as well as the goal of dismantling the structures and practices that contribute to marginalization. This approach can be adapted to a range of organizational and industry contexts, and it will need to be thoughtfully applied in order to be effective in promoting gender equitable workplaces.

The "business case" for investing in women is ubiquitous in both business academia and practice. In March 2017, State Street Global Advisors, one of the world's largest institutional investors, installed the bronze *Fearless Girl* statue across from the famous *Charging Bull* on Wall Street. She stands as the physical manifestation of an ideological wave: that year, both State Street and BlackRock, the world's largest asset manager, launched a campaign to advocate for more women on corporate boards. One decade prior, leaders in philanthropy and finance began a new movement for impact through business that resulted in the *Fearless Girl*: they were brought together by the Rockefeller Foundation to combine their approaches through what has become known as "impact investing." In accordance with this lineage, "win–win" strategies are not based on goodwill alone. Firms in and around the impact investing industry cite white papers (e.g., Carter & Wagner, 2011) and academic research (Jizi & Nehme, 2017; Kim & Starks, 2016; Levi, Li, & Zhang, 2014; McGuinness, 2018) tying women's presence in organizations to various accounting metrics of financial success. So pervasive are the business case arguments for investing in gender diversity that they can be found in policy statements from banks, investment firms, consultancies, as well as governments, including the landmark 2018 California law, SB 826, mandating that every public company has at least one director who is a woman. The win–win formula

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is often promoted as one reason—indeed, *the* reason—for why the resources of investment capital ought to be deployed in support of gender[1] diversity.

However, the fundamental logic undergirding the business case for diversity assumes rather than interrogates the premise that these practices benefit women just as gender diversity advances the bottom line. In fact, recent empirical research challenges the latter. Academic study of gender-based financial outperformance casts significant doubt on the business case. For instance, three recent meta-analyses (Jeong & Harrison, 2017; Pletzer, Nikolova, Kedzior, & Voelpel, 2015; Post & Byron, 2015) summarized more than 100 peer-reviewed articles finding that the relationship between board gender diversity and firm financial performance is effectively zero. That is, there is no scholarly consensus to suggest that the presence of women or the addition of women to a corporate board correlates with or is the causal mechanism by which firms improve financial performance. Claims to the business case approach, then, have inspired rebuffs (Eagly, 2016; Klein, 2017; Solal & Snellman, 2019). As one commentary on firms' claims to the business case for diversity stated:

> They have three things in common: all articulate a business case for hiring more women or people of color; all demonstrate good intentions; and none of the claims is actually supported by robust research findings. (Ely & Thomas, 2020: 116)

Though the business case for gender diversity may not stand up to empirical scrutiny, we argue that it is not reliably good for women, either. By interrogating the epistemic assumptions undergirding the "business case," we argue that valuing diversity this way can result in entrenching bias and excluding women from organizational life. We focus this argument on the paradigmatic and popular case of "gender lens investing." In doing so, we illustrate that, by turning gender diversity into an investible asset, gender lens investing in its current form has relied on pernicious gendered stereotypes to make the business case for investing in women. We have ample reason to reject practices that embed those stereotypes that have for so long limited women's advancement in life, including in business. Instead of making the business case for diversity, which has been effective as a method of persuasion but not of real outcomes for members of historically marginalized groups, we advance a proposal for integrating and assessing *intersectional* diversity in organizations. Through feminist emancipatory theorizing (Cornelissen, Hollerer, & Seidl, 2021; Cunliffe, 2022), we theorize the ways in which an intersectional approach to valuing women (a) acknowledges that the interaction of multiple forms of marginalization, such as gender and class, creates differing experiences of discrimination and strives to (b) recognize and (c) dismantle the institutional structures and practices that maintain patterns of exclusion, rather than merely adding women to the same organizational structure.

INVESTING IN WOMEN

"Gender lens investing" (GLI) describes for-profit investments made "with the intent to address gender issues or promote gender equity" (Global Impact Investing Network, n.d.) based on the belief that financial and gender-related social values are inherently connected, such that "gender is material to financial outcomes and financial outcomes are material to gender" (Kaplan & Vanderbrug, 2014: 38). The central precept of impact investing is the mandate to create positive social impact through investing in businesses (Bugg-Levine & Emerson, 2011; Hehenberger, Mair, & Metz, 2019; Höchstädter & Scheck, 2015), and GLI is one of its fastest growing branches in the field (Saltuk & El Idrissi, 2015). In public markets in the United States, GLI grew from $100 million in 2014 to $2.4 billion in 2018 (Carlile & Pyott, 2018), while, in 2020, the number of private equity, debt, and venture capital funds with an explicit gender lens stands at 138, up 58.6% from 2018 (Biegel, Hunt, & Matteucci, 2020). In 2023, impact investing as an industry, of which GLI is a part, surpassed $1 trillion in assets under management.

As GLI has become a mainstream impact investment strategy, industry actors have begun to standardize gender-related impact metrics,[2] demonstrating

[1] In this paper, we will be using "woman" to draw attention to the socially constructed nature of gender categories and roles, as opposed to the notion of sex (e.g., male, female). We do not claim that sex categories are not also socially constructed. Simply, by "gender," we mean the many social categories of gender identity, including but not limited to "man" and "woman."

[2] In January 2019, the Global Impact Investing Network—the membership network at the heart of the impact investing industry in the United States—added 11 gender-related impact dimensions to its website, including topics such as "improving access to housing for women and gender and sexual minorities" and "reducing gender inequities in governance, leadership, and ownership."

and attempting to unify the broad range of goals at which GLI strategies aim. While some investors funnel capital toward women (e.g., through microfinance) or toward products or services that benefit them (e.g., clean cookstoves), still others aim for gender diversity within organizations themselves (e.g., diverse corporate boards). Investing in gender diverse leadership is, at present, the dominant GLI strategy. In private markets, over half of GLI funds use quantified or unquantified leadership gender mandates as investment screens, such as "We ensure over 50% of the founding team is female," while fully 75% of funds define GLI as "advancing women in leadership: entrepreneurship, C-suite positions, on boards, etc.," outpacing every other definition of the gender lens (Biegel et al., 2020: 10, 18). Similarly, public market strategies like the SHE Index (https://sheindex.com) focus on women in leadership as a key criterion for investment.

To be sure, the inequalities at which GLI aims have been extensively documented. Women are paid less than men (Joshi, Son, & Roh, 2015) and they face significant career progression hurdles (Karam & Jamali, 2013; Tharenou, Latimer, & Conroy, 1994), including at the highest levels of corporate leadership (Bertrand & Hallock, 2001; Chang, Milkman, Chugh, & Akinola, 2019). However, these problems are not binary, affecting women and men in neatly single-axis ways; rather, they are intersectional. By this, we mean that gendered barriers relate to and interlock with multiple forms of marginalization resulting from other social categories. For instance, according to a recent census of Fortune 500 companies, women hold 26.5% of board seats, but women of color hold only 5.7%. While the number of white women serving as board chair has increased since 2016, women of color have not seen the same gains: only one board chair among Fortune 500 companies is a woman of color (Alliance for Board Diversity, 2019). Similarly, while scholars have long studied the gender wage gap (Gharehgozli & Atal, 2020) and the racial wage gap (Gerard, Lagos, Severnini, & Card, 2021), recent work employs an intersectional frame and finds neither a single "race" nor "gender" wage penalty, but, rather, that multiple identities interact in multiplicative ways to penalize women of color (Paul, Zaw, & Darity, 2022).

The solution proposed by many GLI practitioners—to invest in firms with women in leadership—might seem plausible for redressing stark gender inequalities that have both moral and organizational ramifications, and some investments may lead to positive change for some women. However, we argue that the conceptual foundations of the business case for diversity contain epistemic blind spots. To make this argument, we first trace the logic required by investment—capitalization—to show that this method of valuing diversity is necessarily tied to the conceptual process of making women investible. We then argue that the analytic of capitalization, when aimed at "diversity," can further entrench sexism, rather than alleviate it.

Capitalization

We each own things that we value not only because we appreciate them aesthetically or sentimentally, but also because we believe that they might earn money in the future. The ability to trade these things with one another for currency is achieved through "commodification," a process based upon principles of commercial exchange (Braudel, 1977). The process of "capitalization" also relies on a market economy, but its focus is on maximizing profits with respect to future returns (Fisher, 1906) and not on the mere ability to price and trade one good for another (Muniesa et al., 2017). In other words, assets are distinct from commodities because their value is dependent upon the process of estimating their future earnings, not merely with respect to their current market price, their sentimentality, or other innate features (Commons, 1924). The value of an asset from the investor's perspective depends on the expected cumulative returns to the legally recognized financial relationship that will unfold in the future, conditioned by a sense of risk. In an epistemic sense, this is how investors can calculate the value of an asset. Put another way, "value is not something you [the asset] have, but something achieved" through the process of its construction *as an asset* (Commons, 1924; Muniesa et al., 2017: 39). That process—for an investor, determining what has maximum earning potential—is not a fixed state. Rather, capitalization relies on subjective assessments to determine which and how some assets should be valued. Capitalization connects an asset's economic value with its management over time—that is, how to operate that asset such that you derive value from it in the future.

"Impact investing" is likewise based upon a future-oriented perspective, focusing managers not on redressing past injustices—that is, not on the structural forces that have resulted in the lack of diversity in many modern organizations—but on reconfiguring the outcomes of injustice into an opportunity for financial and (purportedly) social value.[3] Here, too, valuation is forward-looking, rather than considering merely the asset's current characteristics or, indeed, the past that brought it into existence. The "win–win" connection between social impact and achieving financial performance has long been recognized in organizational scholarship (Freeman, Wicks, & Parmar, 2004; Lynn, 2021). In the case of gender diversity, capitalization is a process that has real power to determine what leadership teams will exist, whose identity means diversity, and how demographics can be managed to achieve low risk and high future earning potential.

The Investible Woman

Who is the "investible woman"? In other words, on what information do investors trade when they make financial choices based on gender? Considering GLI in this way helps us to understand how gender becomes valued as an asset and made manageable under capitalization. The clearest way to see this logic is through industry and academic discourse. Academics have advanced possible reasons for why gender difference leads to financial performance, such as women being less overconfident (Barber & Odean, 2001); possessing unique skills in the domains of risk management and human resources, among others (Kim & Starks, 2016); and being more risk averse (Bilimoria, 2000; Jizi & Nehme, 2017; Schubert, 2006). For instance, authors of one recent study claim that women may be especially likely to succeed as corporate board members in consumer-focused industries, because of their special "ability to address the needs of multiple stakeholders" (Jizi & Nehme, 2017: 602). These claims matter, in part because investors and lawmakers cite them as empirical evidence to motivate and justify their focus on gender as a means of attaining financial outperformance (e.g., Glenmede, n.d.: 2; Goldman Sachs, n.d.). In fact, at the time of writing, NASDAQ awaits SEC approval to require all listed companies in the United States to have "at least two diverse directors" or face being delisted (Dean, 2020: 1).

In order to make the business case for diversity, these GLI strategies first rely on a logic of difference, in which diversity is conceptualized as a sociodemographic axis of difference between groups of people (Trittin & Schoeneborn, 2017): here, men and women. Second, they insist that investible women qua "diverse" actors reliably behave differently from the status quo of corporate management—that is, from men. This reasoning drives the seeming alignment of values between financial performance and gender diversity through capitalization on women, an evidently monolithic group, as assets. Notice, too, that this distinction is not one only of sociodemographic difference; it is also one of stereotyped gender roles. In the academic and industry discourse above, women leaders become investible when they are presumed to introduce not only different behaviors but also those that are stereotypically feminine: caring for others, doing the hard work of collaboration, listening to others, or urging less risky decisions. Scholars have identified, analyzed, and critiqued the material impacts of gender stereotyping in realms such as politics and law for decades. For instance, political theorists have shown that the reasoning behind gender essentialism of this kind associates women with the stereotypical role as caring for others, being less competitive, more cooperative, and willing to listen to others (Phillips, 1995: 14). This business case, a stereotyped approach to valuing women, misconstrues gender inequality in two ways: (1) through decoupling means with hoped-for ends, and (2) through construing women as a homogenous group. We turn to each of these challenges in turn.

Decoupling means and ends. First, academics have long demonstrated that the mere presence of minoritized bodies is not sufficient for achieving inclusion and felt equality. Scholars of organizations have come to see diversity as emerging socially and iteratively through the policies and practices of a firm (Feldman & Orlikowski, 2011). They have demonstrated the reproduction of inequality in organizations (Kalev, 2009; Wasserman & Frenkel, 2015), including through well-intentioned diversity policies (Janssens & Steyaert, 2019). For example, career mentoring is theorized to reproduce gendered and racialized inequality:

> The enduring unequal position of Black women and men is the result of a particular kind of accomplishment of career mentoring, connected to decision-making and leadership practices that together constitute a site of a hierarchical, masculine, and racialized realm … One can understand how the set of mediated, embodied doings and sayings of career mentoring that produce majority mentors as competent and worthy of privileged positions versus minority mentees as incompetent other belongs to a nexus of practices that in a circular way co-accomplish each other, keeping inequality in existence. (Janssens & Steyaert, 2019: 527)

[3] To be clear, not all impact investments achieve market-rate returns. Some impact investors aim to achieve "concessionary" returns. However, all impact investments are definitionally for-profit.

In this example, the diversity policy (the career mentorship program) is not merely failing to achieve in practice what it purports to do on paper (contribute to the advancement of Black employees in the firm) but it also reproduces the same social hierarchies of power that caused the difference in outcomes for employees of color in the first instance.

Similarly, consider a qualitative study of 10 diversity and equal opportunities officers at universities in the United Kingdom, who served as authors of policy documents required by the Race Relations (Amendment) Act of 2000 (Ahmed, 2007). This Act required all public bodies to create a race equality policy and an action plan. The researcher's interest was in interrogating what the documents do, raising the question of how effectively legally requiring documentation achieves race equality—the stated purpose of the Race Relations (Amendment) Act. Ahmed (2007) found that the production and promotion of these documents did not lead to increased action to reduce inequality, although future actions were articulated in the plans. The distribution and circulation of these reports throughout each university essentially became a version of performative diversity, leading to the decoupling between the aims of the reports and the effectiveness of the means used to achieve them (Bromley & Powell, 2012; Wijen, 2014).

Likewise, in GLI, the rhetoric around promoting gender diversity elides the difference between having a diversity policy (i.e., board gender quotas) and advancing diversity goals (i.e., contributing to gender equality). This decoupling can be pernicious. GLI and other "win–win" strategies "inflict harm because they distract the business world and society from making the difficult choices needed to address pressing social and environmental issues" (King & Pucker, 2020: 35), regardless of how well intentioned.

"Women" as a monolithic group. Second, these approaches to valuing women construe women as a homogenous group. To be sure, one of the key paradoxes of opposing sexism is that, "without conceptualizing women as a group in some sense, it is not possible to conceptualize oppression as a systematic, structured, institutional process" (Young, 1994: 730). Yet, women are an extremely varied group. They are positioned in organizations through complex material practices, such as the gendered division of labor or sexist hiring and promotion patterns, in varied ways.

To provide a small set of documented examples of the heterogeneity of women as a group, scholars have demonstrated the ways in which both racism and sexism inform how racialized women experience inequalities in the workplace (e.g., Corneille, Lee, Allen, Cannady, & Guess, 2019; McDowell & Carter-Francique, 2017; Rosette, Koval, Ma, & Livingston, 2016; Rosette, Ponce de Leon, Koval, & Harrison, 2018). Racialized women disproportionately experience discrimination, harassment, and limited career opportunities, compared to white women (Bloch, Taylor, Church, & Buck, 2021; Smith & Joseph, 2010). These experiences can be even worse for racialized women who are foreign nationals (Sliwa & Johansson, 2014) or who have a disability (Maroto, Pettinicchio, & Patterson, 2019), while white women experience privileges that offset disadvantages associated with their gender (Cheng, 2013; Cheng, 2016), particularly when they are comparatively upper class (Weigt & Solomon, 2008), for instance. These and other empirical studies demonstrate the importance of "accounting for, rather than controlling for, identities that have critical implications for individuals' workplace experiences" (Thatcher, Hymer, & Arwine, 2023: 20).

Reconnecting means and ends through intersectionality. These two challenges to achieving gender equality are connected. By claiming that what matters is the uniqueness of women (or, the feminine) vis-à-vis men (or, the masculine), valuing women as a monolith both erases the heterogeneity within "women" as a group, and also overstates and reifies differences between women and men, limiting the capacity for well-intentioned policies to deliver on their promises of equality and inclusion. As legal scholar MacKinnon reminds us, considering gender as merely sameness and difference between men and women can have the effect of obscuring the ways in which gender operates as an unequal social hierarchy. To make claims to diversity as a function of essential difference between genders—rather than a socially constructed one—is another way of reifying gender hierarchy itself.

Homogenizing claims create a prototype of "woman" that obscures the rich diversity associated with other identities and social categories, including race, sexual orientation, ability, class, and gender identity, that do not neatly align with the investible stereotype. A more robust notion of gender, as well as its implications for business activity, is thereby lost through single-axis discourse (Marlow & Martinez Dy, 2018) that tracks lay theories of white women (Fiske, Cuddy, Glick, & Xu, 2002). If women are said to be valuable because of their presumed collaborative natures, but the archetype of a "cooperative woman" is white (also, presumably, heterosexual, able-bodied, wealthy, and cisgender), then the presumption upon which the investment is made not only reinforces stereotypes of white women, but it also excludes most women. These claims elide differences among women, and thus "*leave behind* those whose experiences cannot be fully explained by a single identity" (Thatcher et al., 2023; emphasis in original).

To overcome both challenges discussed in this section, we need a new approach to valuing women in organizations. Following other scholars in management (Clair, Humberd, Rouse, & Jones, 2019; Thatcher et al., 2023) and ethics (Johnstone-Louis, 2017), we propose that our field's new normal for gender diversity must be intersectional. In the sections that follow, we disrupt the prevailing diversity narrative, bringing the insights gleaned by intersectionality into work on diversity in organizational life.

VALUING DIVERSITY THROUGH INTERSECTIONALITY

Above, we identified and described two challenges presently facing instrumental gender diversity strategies, with GLI as an illustrative example: decoupled goals and outcomes of gender initiatives and the exclusion of most women. Then, we demonstrated that these challenges are connected; they can be explained by their focus on gender as a single, monolithic category of analysis. For scholars and practitioners to move beyond the limitations of single-axis (i.e., gender-only) approaches to valuing women in organizations, we propose a new normal: intersectionality.

In the sections that follow, we describe and defend a theory of how intersectionality should be centered in organizational programs that aim to promote gender diversity in organizations. We advance a feminist emancipatory theory toward two ends: (1) to argue against instrumental theories of women's value, and (2) to propose an alternative intersectional approach to valuing women in organizations. We have already articulated the ways in which instrumental approaches to valuing women can further entrench sexism in organizations. Next, we use intersectionality as a referent to help our readers see the nature of gender in organizations differently (Deetz, 1996). Because this method of theorizing may be unfamiliar to some readers, we first describe the nature of this intervention, and then we present our theory of valuing women through intersectionality.

Feminist Emancipatory Theorizing

Our method of theorizing is "emancipatory," which means we use ethically normative reasoning to critically examine the social and political norms embedded in organizational practices. These norms may be so deeply entrenched as to be nearly invisible to those engaging in them. Emancipatory theorizing seeks out such norms, identifies them as constraints, and "speculate[s] about viable alternatives for reform" (Cornelissen, Hollerer, & Seidl, 2021: 6). These constraining norms include institutionalized racism, sexism, and ableism, among other forms of harmful discrimination and systemic oppression that impact the experience of women in business firms.

We extend this method toward what we term "feminist emancipatory theorizing." Although there is a multiplicity of feminist approaches to theorizing (Jaggar, 1992; Tong, 1993), they share the goals of resisting "practices that perpetuate women's subordination" and envisioning "alternatives that will promote women's emancipation" (Tong, 1993: 10–11).

In keeping with recent contributions to feminist approaches to organizational theorizing, we resist "objective," generalized abstractions that characterize masculinized knowledge, and instead embrace context and subjective and intersubjective experience as the basis for theorizing (Benschop, 2021; Cunliffe, 2022). The task of the feminist emancipatory organization theorist therefore lies in centering the particularities of diverse lived experiences of gendered marginalization and inequality as the basis for understanding organizations, rather than through theoretic abstraction (Collins, 2001). The importance of recognizing the situatedness of experience and in the production of knowledge about organizations derives from feminist epistemology, which has been developed by feminist scholars for decades (Haraway, 1988; Hartsock, 1983; Keller, 1985; Langton, 2009; Longino, 1990; Mohanty, 1984; for empirical applications, see Grenz, 2005; McCorkel & Myers, 2003).

Cornelissen et al. (2021) described emancipatory theorizing as having utopian roots, calling out failed promises and striving to create stronger alternatives for action. Consistent with this approach to theorizing, our manuscript does not offer testable propositions, but, rather, aims at "resonance": insights that offer "ways of seeing something differently … that are embedded within a context but that may resonate with others in different contexts" (Cunliffe, 2022:

14). Following this tradition, we center situated knowledges in our theorizing about valuing women. This epistemic stance recognizes that where a person is socially located impacts their knowledge of business practice, its inputs, and its effects in gendered ways (Kaufmann, 2022). Combining the ideas of epistemic situatedness and emancipatory theorizing, our feminist emancipatory theory aims to expose and delegitimize persistent inequalities in organizations and to imagine better alternatives.

Feminist emancipatory theorizing is particularly relevant for this "new normal" forum, as it "illuminates the limiting or harmful assumptions in past work [here, on gendered inequality in organizations] and … create[s] an opening towards change" (Cornelissen et al., 2021: 13). Social inequality is a grand challenge facing organizations, and inequality is gendered (Acker, 2006). As modern firms are "characterized by employment segregation, marginalization, and the oppression of workers at multiple intersections of gender, race, ethnicity, and class," feminist emancipatory theory provides scholars and managers with the tools to "unpack and delegitimize inequalities in organizations" (Benschop, 2021: 3). We argue that intersectionality should be the new normal for gender scholarship in and about organizations. As we explain further below, intersectionality embraces the reality that multiple "axes of identity" interact to create different experiences of oppression (Collins & Bilge, 2016). An intersectional approach to theorizing gender is indispensable to make inequalities visible and to imagine and manage a path toward change. With urgent political, social, technological, and environmental crises facing contemporary organizations, intersectional gender equality is here offered as a normative goal worth pursuing by scholars and managers alike.

Intersectionality

"Intersectionality" is the study of how multiple forms of social inequality interact to produce individuals' unique experiences of marginalization, as well as the study of the systemic practices that perpetuate these inequities. When legal theorist Kimberlé Crenshaw introduced the concept of *intersectionality* to legal scholarship in the 1980s, she used the term metaphorically to describe what was at stake in the lawsuit brought by Black women employees at General Motors in 1976 (Collins, 2019; Crenshaw, 1989). These employees sued General Motors for discrimination, but the court dismissed their claims, citing the presence of Black men on the factory floor as disproving their claims to racial discrimination, and the presence of white women in clerical jobs as disproving their claims to gender discrimination. Crenshaw's analysis of the lawsuit showed that single-axis categorical thinking about identity (i.e., race only, gender only) led to the exclusion of Black women from anti-discrimination protection under the law, as neither racism nor sexism could account for the employment outcomes of those who experience both simultaneously (Crenshaw, 1988, 1989).

Crenshaw's articulation of intersectionality built on writings of women of color in the Combahee River Collective who described their experiences of exclusion as Black, Chicana, and queer feminists (Moraga & Anzaldua, 2015). These experiences led them to call for radical changes in feminism. Their understanding of what it meant to live at the intersection of multiple forms of discrimination and oppression lay the groundwork for intersectionality as a social justice movement.

> We are actively committed to struggling against racial, sexual, heterosexual, and class oppression, and see as our particular task the development of integrated analysis and practice based upon the fact that the major systems of oppression are interlocking. The synthesis of these oppressions creates the conditions of our lives. As Black women, we see Black feminism as the logical political movement to combat the manifold and simultaneous oppressions that all women of color face. (Extract from the Combahee River Collective Statement, quoted in Moraga & Anzaldua, 2015: 210)

Intersectionality is thus a form of critical inquiry and praxis. In advancing intersectionality as an analytic tool in law, Crenshaw gave a name and framework to an experience that many women of color knew well: the mix of oppressions they faced as women and as racialized minorities (Carbado, 2013; Guy-Sheftall, 1995; Hancock, 2016; Hull, Scott, & Smith, 1982; Moraga & Anzaldua, 2015). In the decades since Crenshaw's (1989) publication, intersectionality has become a familiar and widely used concept in a range of social and health sciences. Together, this research demonstrates that living at the intersection of multiple "axes of oppression" means that many individuals meet neither the social norms for "fitting in" nor the expectations for job performance, government support, and access to resources (Collins & Bilge, 2016) because these expectations are built on assumptions of able-bodied, cisgender, white, heterosexual men. Still, intersectionality remains largely unfamiliar and underemployed as a lens of analysis in organization and management studies (Betti, 2018; Ivancheva & Keating, 2020).

To date, the management research that has adopted an intersectional approach to diversity has done so by identifying more complex identity categories (e.g., Black women) than single-axis variables (e.g., race only, gender only) (e.g., Hall, Hall, Galinsky, & Phillips, 2019; Thatcher et al., 2023). This work is critically important, to be sure. Yet, limiting the application of intersectionality to merely increased demographic awareness through quantitative methods is to overlook its value in providing a lens for seeing and then disrupting systemic patterns and institutional structures that entrench gender hierarchy. Contrasting these approaches, one focused only on demographic predictors of unequal outcomes and the other focused on structural inequality, Dill and Kohlman (2011) offered distinctions between "weak" and "strong" applications of intersectionality. In their categories, *weak* applications of intersectionality introduce and adopt the concept of intersecting identity categories, while *strong* applications scrutinize the operating systems, longstanding assumptions, behavioral patterns, and deeply embedded beliefs to recognize the sources of unequal treatment. Strong applications of intersectionality go beyond reporting differential outcomes of women occupying other marginalized social categories; they identify the structural barriers to gender equity. In this way, strong applications of intersectionality are more emancipatory, contributing to the dismantling and deconstruction of systemic bias and injustice. For clarity, we label these as an "intersectional identity approach" and an "intersectional structural approach." Both are valuable: intersectional identity research and initiatives generally provide a foundation for intersectional, structural, critical activism. Identity work advocates for recognizing the exclusions, while structural work strives to break down barriers and reconstruct more equitable systems. We contrast these approaches in Table 1.

Long recognized for her work as a gender theorist, Joan Acker aligned her analysis of the workplace with considerations familiar to our category of structural intersectionality. She described work organizations as "inequality regimes": locations in which inequalities are invisibly reproduced, despite ostensible organizational efforts to effect change (Acker, 2006). While the major focus of her research was on the disparate treatment of women in the workplace, she also wrote about class and race as factors determining what privileges one had within the organizational regime. She was one of the first to show that organizations may reproduce inequality to varying degrees and with varying sites of influence. Acker's work contributed significantly to feminist emancipatory theorizing, drawing attention to the ways that the routine practices of work organizations constrained and oppressed women. Racism, classism, and sexism were—and are—deeply entwined with many of these routine practices.

For example, we now know that the tasks that are implicitly expected to keep the basic functions of a workplace running smoothly are often divided by gender, such that women perform the bulk of nonpromotable tasks (Babcock, Recalde, Vesterlund, & Weingart, 2017). Similarly, a comparative study of law firms demonstrated unequal opportunities for junior paralegals: men were given actual legal work to perform, white women were expected to serve as helpful aids, and Black women were assigned secretarial tasks—and their subordinate roles were made clear to all (Pierce, 1995). Likewise, Black women's discrimination claims are believed less than those of more "prototypical" group members (Ponce de Leon & Rosette, 2022): white women who experience gender discrimination and Black men who experience racial discrimination (Smith, Watkins, Ladge, & Carlton, 2019). Acker's description of such processes within organizations provided the foundational theorizing for subsequent structural intersectionality research by a new generation of gender scholars (Healy, Tatli, Ipek, Ozturk, Seierstad, & Wright, 2019).

Gendered and racialized divisions of labor have material implications for employee well-being and remuneration. These examples demonstrate the stubborn and often unnoticed ways that gender is invoked to recreate systems that discriminate and harm. Toward the end of her career, Acker (2012: 214) ultimately recognized that "gendered processes do not stand alone, but intersect with and are shaped by race and class processes, as well as other forms of inequality and exclusion." Despite this recognition over a decade ago, the treatments of intersectionality that dominate management scholarship fall within identity intersectionality, rarely including either sustained consideration of how the multiple axes of difference reinforce the power structures embedded within the organization or how these could be dismantled.

Advancing an Intersectional Theory of Valuing Women in Organizations

Here, we deploy intersectionality toward both identity and structural applications of intersectionality in

TABLE 1
Contrasting Instrumental and Intersectional Approaches to Diversity

	Instrumental approach	Identity intersectional approach	Structural intersectional approach
What are the goals of a gender diversity initiative?	• The organization looks more like the people it wants to reach as customers or employees • Profit • Competitive advantage	• Reduce bias • Integrate the previously excluded • Value diversity work as work to be compensated • Eliminate tokenism	• Recognize and dismantle practices that maintain hegemonic power and hierarchy • Redistribute authority and power beyond the hegemonic group • Establish ongoing reflection and monitoring within organization for continued progress
What constitutes successful gender diversity?	• People with different genders than "us" are incorporated into our organization • This inclusion of diverse others occurs when and where it improves (or is supposed to improve) firm performance	• Recognize intersecting experiences of marginalization • Measure the presence and progress of women • All women can participate in the organization without experiencing stereotyping or skepticism about their abilities	• Interrogate the firm's practices to identify sources of bias and marginalization • Reduce and eliminate oppressive practices, attitudes, and rules • Engage collectively on constructive collaboration for the work needed for change and determining who will lead it
How will women succeed at the organization?	• Learn from experienced mentors • Excel at expected behavior and roles, even if reinforcing stereotyped strengths • Recruit other women • Be an internal spokesperson for women and an external spokesperson for diversity	• Help to educate and bring awareness to different identities and insights within the organization • Performance appraisals explicitly value efforts to support diversity • Create, maintain, and enforce a workplace free from racism, sexism, and other -isms • Promotions to positions of power not as an "other" but as part of "us"	• Exercise voice in speaking out about experiences, and calling out problems, without incurring penalty • Differences are valued as strengths, not as weaknesses or stereotypes • Fair compensation for all contributions, including work to reduce barriers • Opportunities for promotion are open to everyone

the context of gender diversity in organizations. First, intersectionality draws attention to "the relationships among multiple dimensions and modalities of social relations and subject formations" in analyses of social phenomena such as (in)equity (McCall, 2005: 1771). An intersectional analysis from this view begins with a greater awareness of stereotypes for behavior (Hall et al., 2019) and the inequitable positioning of individuals within an organization's hierarchy (Köllen, 2021) in order to resist those stereotypes in promoting equity within a firm. Second, intersectionality can also be deployed as analytical tool in the context of organizations "to capture and engage contextual dynamics of power"—that is, the structural and institutionalized components of organizing that influence (in)equity in firms (Cho, Crenshaw, & McCall, 2013: 788). Understood this way, we view intersectionality as a theoretical paradigm that provides a framework to understand how categories of social difference (e.g., gender, ethnicity, race, sexuality, class, caste, age, dis/ability, refugee and immigration status) interact with structures of power to explain unequal material effects experienced by women within a particular context.

Intersectional thinking is fundamentally critical of work organizations, for the same reason that Acker described most workplaces as inequality regimes: they are the sites of much of the social and economic inequality in our societies. For too long, well-intentioned approaches to diversity have remained non-intersectional and, as we have shown, further entrenched inequality. To address and repair this inequality, scholars and practitioners must go beyond instrumentally valuing diversity to take on the harder work of deploying structural intersectionality. In this section, we present an approach for valuing diversity through intersectionality, taking as a focal case the strategy of impact investing in and for women.

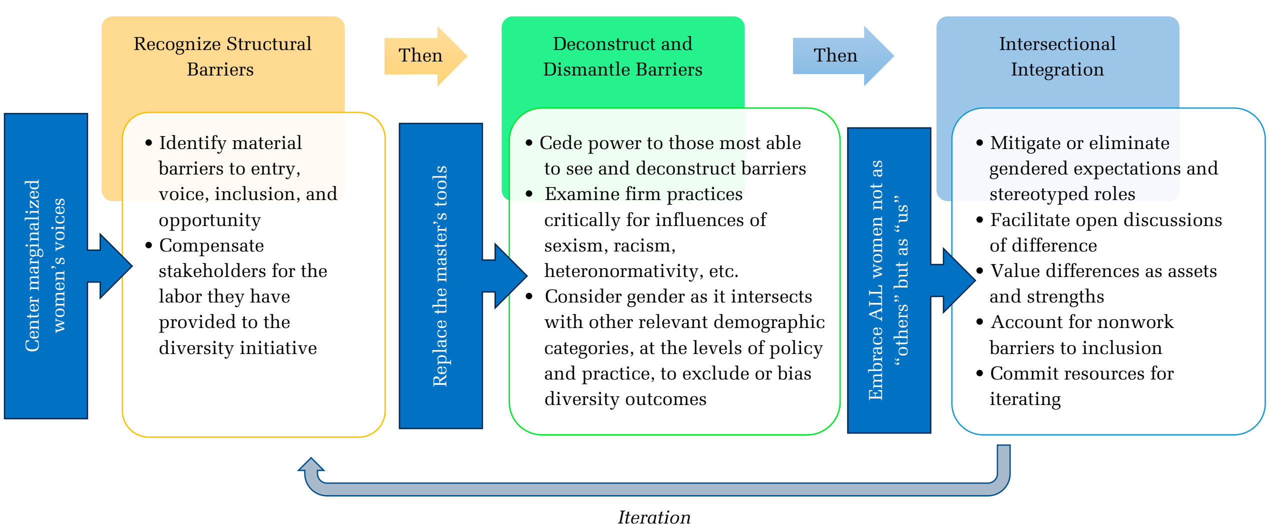
Extending this view, we advocate shifting the focus of diversity work from the acquisition of "others" to critical reflection on existing practices that create structural barriers. Doing so pushes the manager to evaluate their own processes, structures, and modes of decision-making as potential barriers to equity. To achieve this, an intersectional approach to valuing gender diversity in organizations requires three iterative steps, shown in Figure 1, which should be adapted to the unique organizational context:

1. Recognition and open acknowledgment of institutional structures and practices that have created barriers to entry, voice, and opportunities within an organization
2. Deconstruction and dismantling of these structural barriers
3. Integration of people who have been previously excluded at all levels of the organization.

This approach is both temporal and recursive. The steps shown in Figure 1 should be understood as preceding one another in time, as evidenced by the straight arrows at the top of the figure—that is, managers must first recognize structural barriers before effectively dismantling them. These steps should also be viewed as requiring recursive consideration, as evidenced by the curved arrow at the bottom of the figure—that is, once marginalized individuals are integrated at a firm, stakeholders ought to again create a coalition for recognizing structural barriers. In the sections that follow, we discuss our theory and apply its insights to the case of GLI.

Recognizing structural barriers. A key insight of intersectional thinking is that women do not all share a common experience of gender oppression or privilege (hooks, 1985). Rather, gender oppression itself is experienced differently by a woman according to her other experiences of social categorization and marginalization, such as her racial–ethnic and class position (Spelman, 1988). The connection between the experience of discrimination and the resultant knowledge of oppressive power structures has been explored by feminist theorists (e.g., Collins, 2001; Guy-Sheftall, 1995; Hull et al., 1982; Moraga & Anzaldua, 2015) before and since being explicitly applied to the context of the American judicial system by Crenshaw. Intersectionality thus identified the erasure of Black women's oppression in the United States and acknowledged Black women as epistemic subjects. Put another way, single-axis approaches—such as gender-only approaches to theorizing women in organizations—should be understood as tools of systemic oppression.

FIGURE 1
Valuing Gender Diversity through Intersectionality



To recognize structural barriers, stakeholders must first acknowledge this core insight of intersectionality: people marginalized in organizations are better positioned to recognize those structural barriers than are individuals who have not experienced them in the first place. An implication of this insight relevant for recognizing structural barriers is that, for instance, working-class Black lesbians know something different about discriminatory processes because of their intersectional experiences of the effects of class, racism, homophobia, and misogyny. This experiential knowledge is particularly valuable to inform and educate those who have not experienced exclusion firsthand. As leaders in organizations work to identify structural barriers, an essential first step is to invite people who may have been excluded to help inform and guide this work. These people have a clearer understanding of how the norms of the organization—such as the criteria for promotions, what experiences are deemed qualifications, expectations of travel, or social interactions outside of the regular work environment where networking or skill acquisition occurs (Werner, 2012)—may be excluding people systematically. One of the major contributions of intersectional theory has been to critically challenge the exclusion of women of color from the production of knowledge (Collins, 2019). The epistemic upshot of practicing intersectionality has vast implications for diversity management. When the voices of women from intersecting demographic groups are heard in identifying the material barriers to inclusion, their experience and knowledge can be honored and valued by the firm in shaping the ways in which inclusion can happen. In other words, identifying structural barriers is less likely to happen when the power to shape policy remains centered with the dominant group.

Feminist organizational scholars show us how to deploy this insight in practice. For example, a longitudinal, participatory research study with a Ghanaian cocoa company exposed why a gender corporate social responsibility (CSR) program was failing to attract and retain women. By centering in data collection and theorizing the lived experiences of the women intended to benefit from the CSR program, the author demonstrated why the CSR program failed and revealed novel avenues for progress. Rather than presume that all women shared a common experience of structural constraints, the researcher engaged directly with women to parse their differing material barriers to success. Ultimately, she suggested that the company pivot the CSR program from providing women training for alternate sources of income including batik, jewelry crafting, and soap and cassava processing, to addressing structural constraints that prevented participation in the labor market in the first place. The analysis revealed that some women were systematically excluded from full labor market participation due to social norms of childcare, and thus they required time-saving devices like bicycles and water wells to "reduce the drudgery and time burden of unpaid care" and, in turn, to increase their capacity for paid employment (McCarthy, 2018: 339). McCarthy's study is an effective demonstration of how centering the lived experiences of women, while being attuned to gender's intersections as well as relevant local context, can advance knowledge of organizing.

GLI, as we have pointed out, is argued to benefit the investor, while also improving the status and opportunities for equality for women. An underlying assumption is that the investors have power (by means of their strategic investments) to capitalize on diversity, as well as to strengthen and improve the companies they choose to invest in. Investors wield power of deciding what that improvement will consist of, how it will be implemented, and who will benefit from their investment. Recent critical research on impact investing asks, "How does the design of the impact investing field affect its capacity to address structural inequalities?" (Casasnovas & Jones, 2022: 1). The authors argue for the inclusion of vulnerable stakeholders at each stage of the investment decisions and implementation steps.

Their recommendations, while not explicitly intersectional, align with our understanding of the requirements of intersectional work. They find that "broadening the voices of decision-makers determines a specific impact approach and its subsequent capacity to address inequality" (Casasnovas & Jones, 2022: 11). Their approach of "giving voice" is one that demands careful consideration of who is included and who is excluded in the various stages of raising funds, designing investment instruments, creating advisory boards, and determining metrics for success. Our theory suggests that investors should not only center the voices of marginalized women in the organizations into which they invest, but they should do so in a way that acknowledges and values that labor. Diversity work is work. To ask marginalized people to educate the holders of power about the oppression they experience is to ask them to do difficult and potentially painful work. GLI practitioners should view the identification of structural barriers to women's flourishing in portfolio companies as labor that is compensated fairly.

Dismantling structural barriers. The second step follows the acknowledgment of structures and practices that are likely to be deeply entrenched as "the way things have always been done." For the many people who benefit from these structures, and even for those disadvantaged by them (Liaquat, Jost, & Balcetis, 2023), they are hard to see as discriminatory. The reasons for their practice may well be defended as the most logical or efficient (Werner, 2012). Yet, they may not work to create equal access to resources for those whose voices are not heard in the inertia of hegemony. The business case for gender diversity argues that the mere inclusion of more women will benefit the organization. If, as discussed above, simply adding women to organizational leadership or visible board positions can be a means of obscuring the ongoing practices of inequality and exclusive access to power throughout the organization, then such additive measures effectively become one of the structures perpetuating inequality instead of diminishing it. Intersectional work, instead, requires dismantling institutional barriers and deeply embedded structural practices that contribute to inequities. By dismantling these structural barriers, organizations can not only contend with their culpability for maintaining those systems in the past, but they can better promote effective gender equity in the future.

A well-known example of a gender diversity policy aimed at removing structural barriers pertains to how auditions are held for professional orchestras. Although the judges intended to be fair and equitable in their assessments, internalized gender bias had previously influenced their judgment, resulting in few women being selected. When auditions were staged with judges unable to see the physical body of the performer and forced to judge the performance without knowing the gender, race, age, or other identifiers of the performer, more women were judged to be outstanding and selected for the orchestra (Goldin & Rouse, 2000). This, as we show in Table 1, is an example of an identity intersectional diversity policy, which was aimed only at affecting outcomes based on gender. However, while blind auditions proved efficacious for increasing gender diversity, this increase was experienced only for white women, not for women of color. While the initial "remedy" did make a structural change in the audition and selection process to diminish the bias accompanying visual assessment, the resulting change was only a single-axis shift. The orchestras became more inclusive of white women.

Today, according to the League of American Orchestras, professional orchestras remain one of America's least racially diverse institutions (Doeser, 2016). While the promise of pure meritocracy spurred blind auditions as a gender diversity policy, the League has noted that it failed to account for structural features of orchestra auditions—such as the heavy financial costs associated with traveling to audition—that disproportionally affect young musicians of color. With the recognition that who benefits from well-intentioned diversity practices is an intersectional issue, not one that merely conforms to a binary gender schema, blind auditions are coming under new scrutiny (Tommasini, 2020). The League has begun to recognize additional barriers for aspiring young musicians of color to achieve access to the same credentials and development experiences as rising white musicians. As noted above, the harm of existing structures is often hard to recognize when there are few members of the disadvantaged group (here, those of lower income, and also Black and Brown musicians) among the decision-makers (in this case, the audition judges). As the orchestra example painfully demonstrates, even well-intended attempts to be more inclusive can have unintended consequences that inadvertently limit the diversification of an organization—in that case, by systematically excluding people of color. A structural intersectional approach to valuing diversity is therefore necessarily iterative, focusing on removing the structural barriers to equity recursively, monitoring outcomes, and engaging in the process for the long term.

"The master's tools will never dismantle the master's house" (Lorde, 1993). This title of Audre Lorde's presentation at the Second Sex Conference raises the challenging questions of how to dismantle structural barriers, who will do that work, and whose tools will be used. These words argue that "the way things have always been done" will not suffice. These "tools" are insufficient precisely because they involve approaching the challenge with the same people in charge and by using the same methods of gathering information and identifying constructive solutions by agreement of those at the top of the management hierarchy. In the same talk, Lorde also decried the expectation that women of color take on the task of educating white men and women about their lives and needs. If not by the master's tools, nor by the expectation that women will shoulder this burden (Eaton & Warner, 2021), how will change happen?

A full exploration of methods needed to dismantle structural barriers is beyond the scope of this paper, but organizations and scholars can draw upon extant work to guide their efforts. For instance, a recent review of nearly 150 empirical articles examining intersectional experiences of women in organizations outlined the ways in which "employees, managers, and organizations can resist such influences [those of racism, sexism, heteronormativity] to create better environments for those at the intersection of multiple identities" (Thatcher et al., 2023: 12–13). From their review of intersectional gender literature, these scholars concluded that organizations indeed "have the potential to use their power to proactively implement policies and programs and empower managers to replace or offset biased organizational power structures with more equitable ones, improving workers' experiences of intersectionality" (Thatcher et al., 2023: 14). Extending this insight, our theory insists that success of efforts to implement such policies and programs aimed at dismantling structural barriers is squarely a function of context, such that diversity work must begin first with the recognition of these structures' manifestation at the organization as experienced by the marginalized women themselves. Echoing Lorde, the balance of power must shift. If the same "masters" continue to hold the power to determine the shape of diversity policies, while deigning to include a few "others" in the room, deconstruction will not happen.

How can GLI practitioners engage in intersectional diversity work to dismantle structural barriers for their investees? Beyond identifying inequalities at varied levels of investee firms, GLI practitioners should focus their efforts on understanding and removing structural features of portfolio companies that result in those inequalities. Take the well-known metaphor for the structural barrier to women's leadership, the "glass ceiling." The term itself first came into use in 1986 when two *Wall Street Journal* reporters coined the phrase to describe the invisible barrier that blocks women from top jobs in corporate America (Mattis & Scheinholtz, 1994: 1). Yet, scholars have long argued that this barrier is not invisible at all, but, rather, is the result of systematic prejudice and stereotyping of women as primarily the provisioners of unpaid caring labor (Chamberlain, 1999; Morrison, 1992; Morrison, White, Van Velsor, & Center for Creative Leadership, 1987). Research, in fact, demonstrates that gendered expectations regarding family responsibilities systematically derail many women's careers (Ely & Padavic, 2020), and the unequal split of household labor influences the employment, promotion, and upskilling of women of color in global supply chains (McCarthy & Moon, 2018; Werner, 2012).

One place for GLI practitioners to focus their efforts would be here: How do expectations around family and reproductive labor influence the selection, remuneration, and promotion of women at portfolio companies? Do those firms have adequate and equitable policies regarding the provisioning of caring labor for employees of all genders? Do expectations for leaders at the company explicitly or implicitly reflect white and/or masculine work patterns and family roles? Investors should therefore expand the scope of factors considered for inclusion into an investment portfolio, beyond merely counting the number of women in leadership, to critically examining the barriers result in gendered inequality in leadership. One GLI strategy that attempts to dismantle structures preventing women from achieving the highest levels of firm leadership is the EQUL IQ Engender Equality ETF (New York Life Investments, n.d.). The strategy considers gender at all levels of the organization, as well as the policies a potential investee organization has in place to support workers. The Solactive Equileap U.S. Gender Equality Index (Solactive, n.d.), which EQUL tracks, considers whether the investee has adopted rules for equal compensation; paid parental leave policies; flexible work provisions; and practices aimed at gender equality across the firm's supply chain, including a commitment to human rights, safety, and freedom from violence, abuse, and sexual harassment. In adopting factors that are salient for those at different intersections of gender identity, EQUL is one step closer to recognizing the heterogeneity of the gendered experience and removing structural barriers for women beyond those who make it to corporate leadership.

GLI strategies that focus merely on screening for women in top management do not necessarily disrupt and fundamentally alter those institutions that have resulted in the inequities at which diversity policies aim. Such methods of promoting diversity may advance the addition of some women into the upper echelons of corporate America (Haslam, 2004), but they do so at the cost of stabilizing and reinforcing corporate norms that undervalue women, excluding them both from positions of power and from receiving equal treatment in hiring, promotion, voice, and remuneration with men. Our theory suggests that it is imperative for individual investors to engage in their own contexts, industries, and geographies to determine how best to dismantle relevant structural barriers. EQUL offers some examples, but more exist. An intersectional approach to diversity requires members of an organization to scrutinize practices and policies that maintain power structures that systematically exclude women and other minorities, including transgender women, women of color, queer women, socioeconomically marginalized women, and women with disabilities, from equal consideration and opportunities (see Table 1) so that they can be effectively dismantled.

Intersectional integration. Finally, organizations must work to integrate the previously excluded, not as "others" or as "diverse individuals" but as peers, at all levels of the organization. Since the mid-1960s, various forms of affirmative action and racial equity laws in the United Kingdom and North America have attempted to create standards and requirements that would improve work and educational opportunities for those who had previously been excluded on the basis of gender, race, religion, nationality, and other legally protected categories. A careful look at the evolution of diversity programs and initiatives demonstrates that compliance approaches undermine serious and significant efforts to transform an organization culture and are insufficient to remove institutional practices that perpetuate sexism and racism (Creary, McDonnell, Ghai, & Scruggs, 2019; Jonsen & Ozbilgin, 2014). While these laws and initiatives did, in fact, open many previously closed doors in universities and organizations, they were not sufficient to create racial or gender equity. They did not change the normative cultures.

Two dominant paradigms of diversity management—the assimilation paradigm and the differentiation paradigm—both fall short of creating advantages for the organization and individuals through integration of minorities (Thomas & Ely, 1996). In the *assimilation* approach, greater numbers of women and minorities are brought into the organization and are expected to adapt to the existing organizational context. Yet, merely including more and different women in an organization is not a practice that identifies or dismantles the structures that contribute to their marginalization. In the *differentiation* approach, organizations strive to value differences by exploiting them; for example, Latinx people are hired so that they can market existing products to other Latinx people, and French-speaking people are valued because they can manage the accounts in Francophone countries. The limitation of the differentiation approach is that "diverse" individuals become limited to roles deemed valuable to existing leadership, populated by hegemonic social groups. In these paradigms, "others" are included into the firm either as instrumental assets or as mandated by affirmative action. As a result, these individuals can struggle to be seen or heard as anything other than their identity group affiliation or, worse, the stereotype of their identity group affiliation, which significantly limits their contributions and opportunities. Again, as the orchestra example demonstrates, such approaches may not give thought to whether the organization's recruitment and promotion processes, products, or services are inaccessible to the women that organizations intend to include.

Instead, we advocate a paradigm of intersectional integration, in which all women are recognized as equal peers and are fairly compensated for their skills and contributions. All women, here, includes Black and Brown women, queer and trans women, Indigenous and First Nations women, Latinx, Asian, able-bodied and disabled women; all women, regardless of their religion, nationality, sexuality, gender, class, or identity group that may categorize them as "others." This approach acknowledges that trust is earned, and integration is hard won throughout all levels of an organization. Diversity scholars advocate that successful integration is facilitated by open discussions of differences and a revaluing of differences as strengths and assets, even when this requires organizational adaptation and change (Ely & Thomas, 2020; Thomas & Ely, 1996). While current paradigms of integration hold some promise for getting more women into firms, intersectional integration suggests that organizational adaptation and change must occur for integration of these women at all levels of the organization to be sustained. As Figure 1 illustrates, the deconstruction of embedded structures is necessary prior to new constructions. Without altering the structural barriers that lead to inequitable distributions of power in firms, organizations will not make progress toward empowering and truly integrating those who have been excluded and marginalized by extant practices. Further, intersectional integration requires inviting the marginalized into the inner sanctum of "us," to join the rooms of power where change occurs. This integration therefore requires the commitment of resources for iterating the process shown in Figure 1, to account for new and newly seen structural barriers.

Consider the intersectional issue of violence against women. Intimate partner violence is an important factor in women's economic security, including their employment ability, job stability, and career progression (Postmus, Plummer, McMahon, Murshid, & Kim, 2012; Riger & Staggs, 2004).

Researchers in Canada show the importance of considering other factors such as race and indigeneity (Tarshis, Alaggia, & Logie, 2022): First Nations, Métis, and Inuit (Indigenous) women are at a disproportionate risk of intimate partner violence (61%), compared with non-Indigenous women (44%) (Heidinger, 2021). In the United States, prominent LGBTQ+ organizations such as the Gay and Lesbian Alliance Against Defamation (GLAAD) and the Human Rights Campaign document and demonstrate the intersectional nature of violence against women according to gender identity, sexuality, and race. Recent years have seen rising violent crime against transgender women (Anti-Defamation League, 2023; GLAAD, 2023; Human Rights Campaign, 2022), particularly against transgender women of color, who comprise 80% of all known killings of transgender, non-binary, and gender nonconforming people (Human Rights Campaign, 2021). For organizations and investors hoping to advance the inclusion of women, understanding the overlapping nature of crises women face—gender-based violence, immigrant status, gender identity, and race—is necessary to support the women whom they already employ and to integrate new women hires into the organization successfully (MacDougall, Walia, & Wise, 2022).

For investors, some relevant questions include: Are women provided with voice and opportunity, or are they counted and set aside? Are our conceptions of gender inclusive of gender non-conforming and transgender women? Are women homogenized, tokenized, or marginalized explicitly or implicitly at this firm? Do women feel heard? Are women asked to adopt gendered stereotypes to be viewed as legitimate at work? Because the experience of racialization at work often decreases survivors' ability to cope with trauma, contribute to their jobs, and maintain employment (Chellapermal, 2022), investors should seek to understand the ways in which their current and intended employees experience racialization and trauma on the job. Then, intersectional integration requires crafting recruitment, onboarding, and promotion policies and practices that take into account women's varied, material realities of gender oppression that inevitably spill over from the so-called "private" sphere into the domain of work.

DISCUSSION

A venerable history of thought in management scholarship, and in this journal in particular, has engaged the "essentially contested" views of CSR, in which scholars conceive of social action as either instrumental or injunctive, meaning reflective of either the business case versus an ethical rationale (Jones, 1995; Mitnick, Windsor, & Wood, 2021). Those scholars working in the "instrumental" tradition concern themselves with how firms can manage sociodemographic diversity of individual employees in order to gain competitive advantage, either through firm financial performance (Post & Byron, 2015) or nonmarket strategy (Fernandez-Feijoo, Romero, & Ruiz-Blanco, 2014). On the other hand, those in the more critical "injunctive" tradition offer normative arguments for the value of diversity, divorced from the business case (Ozkazanc-Pan, 2019; Pullen, Rhodes, McEwen, & Liu, 2019; Trittin & Schoeneborn, 2017). Key to this schism is a distinction in what is meant by "value"—that is, whether performance on metrics like diversity ought to be valued for what they achieve instrumentally, or for the value they have in themselves (Donaldson, 1994; Donaldson & Walsh, 2015; Terjesen & Sealy, 2016)—and the debate demonstrates that determining value is neither objective nor neutral (Mazzucato, 2018).

We have illuminated this debate by demonstrating that valuing gender diversity via a "business case" analytic can undermine the very goals at which well-intended diversity policies aim. Treating gender diversity as instrumentally value-adding to business can mitigate and erase the contributions of women in organizations, and, in this manuscript, we have explained why: the structures of bias and constraint will remain, resulting in ineffective, unsustainable diversity programs. Instead, for modes of valuing women to contribute to real change, we have argued that valuation must consider not only the demographic patterns of corporate life but must also commit to identifying and disrupting the power structures that sustain those patterns. Rather than continuing to engage in the practices that maintain the power structure of investment decisions with a few more women sitting at the table of power, the measurement of gender diversity needs to be reconsidered in new terms.

With the recognition that the grand challenge of gender equality is intersectional, scholars and practitioners alike have disrupted the assumption, visible in much management and business ethics scholarship, that we can meaningfully operationalize "women" as monolithic category in our work. In this manuscript, we have argued that the "new normal" for valuing women requires treating gender intersectionally. By identifying and dismantling structural barriers to *intersectional* gender equality, considering other relevant categories of social difference—including but not limited to race/ethnicity, caste, age, ability, and immigration status—we can better ensure that women's voices are heard and valued in efforts to end gender oppression and inequity in organizations.

Implications for Research on Diversity

We posit intersectionality as the new normal for diversity scholarship and practice. For too long, scholars have treated gender—as well as other social categories, such as gender, age, and sexuality—as homogenous. This treatment manifests, for instance, through a single, predictive variable in empirical scholarship or as a cohesive, homogenous construct in theoretical work. Intersectionality contests this view. All women—or, similarly, all Black people, young people, and LGBTQ+ people—do not experience the world in the same way, and to pretend that they do is to reinforce structures of oppression that perpetuate sexism, racism, classism, ableism, and other forms of exclusion in organizations and society. Instead, adopting a genuinely intersectional view of gender, race, sexuality, and so on requires us to acknowledge that the experience of marginalization is a result of intersecting axes of social difference, which result in unique and nonoverlapping ways of experiencing and thus of knowing about the world.

Embracing both an identity intersectional and structural intersectional view of gender raises important methodological challenges for organizational research on the experiences of women. How can researchers adopt an intersectional analytic while also deploying "gender" as a salient category? We encourage scholars to view this task a delicate balancing act, which requires respecting the heterogeneity of women's experiences while also making use of gender as a social category in order to oppose systematic structures of oppression (Garcia, 2021; Young, 1994). Certainly, the importance and current deficiency of gender-disaggregated data, let alone more detailed data that capture the complexity of sociodemographic difference by factors like sexuality and race, has been widely cited as a primary challenge to empirical research (Berik, van der Meulen Rodgers, & Seguino, 2009; Doss, 2021; Thompson, Vassallo, Finfer, & Woodward, 2022) in identity intersectional scholarship.

Our theory also raises deeper methodological questions about how scholars should operationalize, measure, and theorize the relationships between social categories and structural power in their work (Thatcher et al., 2023). While further research is needed to examine and craft solutions to this challenge, feminist scholars offer some intersectional methodologies for empirical work about gender, which would center "relationships of inequality among already constituted social groups [and] explicate those relationships, and doing so requires the provisional use of categories" (McCall, 2005: 1784–1785). Extending McCall, we advocate, at minimum, interrogating rather than assuming the boundaries between and within social categories (e.g., who is included in descriptions of "women" and "women's experiences"?) as an important first step in applying an intersectional approach to both conceptual and empirical management scholarship.

Implications for Research on "Business Case" Solutions

While the ultimate win–win case for dismantling inequality—increased human prosperity for all—has long been advocated by scholars (Aiyar & Ebeke, 2020), socially advantaged groups nevertheless continue to implement policies that perpetuate inequality (Kuziemko, Buell, Reich, & Norton, 2014). While some have argued that intentionally framed "win–win" strategies could increase advantaged groups' support for equality, research suggests that this is not necessarily the case. For example, despite the benefits to be gleaned from enhanced racial equality, white Americans perceive various forms of equality with Black Americans as threatening (Anicich, Jachimowicz, Osborne, & Phillips, 2021) and anxiety inducing (Danbold & Huo, 2015), and can react with increased bias (Norton & Sommers, 2011). The misperception by dominant group members that equality harms them remains a pernicious challenge to crafting effective diversity strategies in organizations, and it demonstrates the importance of accounting both for the "wins" and as well as the limitations and negative impact associated with social and environmental initiatives.

How can scholars and practitioners encourage allyship instead of reactance from those who currently hold power? The call for dominant group members' buy-in is particularly urgent, given how effective dominant group members are when they are allies in promoting equality (Hussain, Tangirla, & Sherf, 2023). First, empirical work remains to be done by individuals and organizations to disabuse themselves of diversity-related biases and falsehoods that prevent collective flourishing. As two recent review articles show, research on prejudice reduction is nascent but promising (Chang & Milkman, 2020; Paluck, Porat, Clark, & Green, 2021), and field-based experimentation demonstrates that one-off diversity training results in persistent effects for attitudinal change in favor of gender diversity (Chang, Milkman, Gromet, Rebele, Massey, Duckworth, & Grant, 2019). Our theory would suggest that this work must be intersectional in order to be effective. Further empirical research on "what works" to mitigate negative outcomes—here, to debias dominant group members—and to promote diversity, intersectionally understood, is urgently needed.

A second response to the challenge of reactance is normative in nature. As stakeholder theorists have long argued, the "separation thesis"—the idea that one can separate business practices from the values that motivate and shape it—is false (Freeman, 1994). The same, we argue, is true for considering win–win claims to impact. Valuing social and environmental impact instrumentally reveals the underlying organizational values of efficiency and profit maximization inherent to capitalization. In contrast, we advocate for a deeper integration of the ethical values of human dignity and diversity (Donaldson, 2021) in research on allyship and reactance. These values provide a basis for action and a focus for policy-making, as reflected in the first step of our theoretical model: valuing the knowledge of those who have been marginalized by and in the organization. In this, we align ourselves with Ijeoma Oluo (2018), who argued that accomplices, not just performative allies, are essential for lasting change.

More broadly, integrating relevant ethical values is particularly germane for scholars of social impact, including CSR, sustainability, and social entrepreneurship. Our theory suggests that, without an honest and critical examination of how impact occurs and who experiences that impact in a particular context, instrumental policies and practices can both overstate their impacts and underappreciate their negative consequences. Consider microfinance, a now decades-long strategy to include the poor in formal markets in an effort to mitigate poverty. The Grameen Bank was founded in 1976 with the goal of "empowering the marginalized poor in Bangladesh through microcredit," and, today, a full 98% of the bank's borrowers are women, who are responsible for the bank's "lucrative" loan recovery rate of nearly 97% (Grameen Bank, n.d.). While including women in markets is here taken as a "win–win" relationship for both social and economic progress, linking women's productivity and poverty alleviation with economic growth (Chant, 2008: 172), feminist scholars have long argued that the gains for women as a function of market inclusion may be overstated (Benería, Berik, & Floro, 2015; Kabeer & Natali, 2013). Indeed, some have flatly rejected the win–win claims of microfinance, given null results (Duflo, Banerjee, Glennerster, & Kinnan, 2013), negative outcomes including overindebtedness (Brickell et al., 2020; Puliyakot & Pradhan, 2015), and increased social, economic, and environmental vulnerability, particularly of women (Banerjee & Jackson, 2017).

Under the "win–win" logic familiar to much impact-related scholarship, it is too easy to obscure the destruction of social value and to avoid considering negative consequences. Adopting an intersectional approach, instead, requires scholars to eschew the assumption of achieving impact alongside financial performance and, rather, to embrace the harder work of testing that assumption. The above example of a Ghanaian CSR initiative vividly demonstrates the promise of such an approach, as well as the perils of continuing with business as usual (McCarthy, 2018). Our theory suggests that researchers interested in the relationship of business and society should include the voices of marginalized stakeholders in examining, testing, and theorizing about the solutions ostensibly benefiting them.

Implications for Diversity Practitioners and Gender Lens Investors

The billions of dollars deployed for gender equality through impact investing, microfinance, ESG, and social entrepreneurship are evidence of demand for real change. It is an empirical question—and one worth further investigation—whether these individuals and firms in fact desire intersectional and equitable outcomes. To the extent business firms and investment funds espousing the goal of gender equality do contain individuals sincerely desirous of change, this approach is for them.

To begin implementing intersectionality into their practice, we encourage managers and investors to first scrutinize their own practices, in part to learn and to demonstrate what supporting diversity means. They need to engage early and often in the humbling process of centering the knowledge of those in their own organizations who have been marginalized to identify barriers to equality, which we have shown are visible to some but not to others.

Then, managers and investors must remain accountable to pursuing those gender-oriented aims as well as possible risks to achieving those aims.

To craft intersectional GLI strategies, we encourage investors to explore approaches currently available in practice. We have already mentioned Equileap, which was developed in accordance with the Women's Empowerment Principles established by UN Women and UN Global Compact and enables investors to consider not merely gender representation in leadership but an investee firm's commitment to dismantling structural barriers to women's equality at all levels, such closing the gender pay gap, providing paid parental leave, and paying a living wage to workers at all levels of the firm (Equileap, 2019). Similarly, the GLI think tank Criterion Institute offers various resources for investors to move beyond counting women toward truly valuing gender in the investment process. Criterion Institute aligns with our theory by considering the hierarchical, intersectional power dynamics of gender (Criterion Institute, 2014) to address issues such as gender-based violence (Criterion Institute, 2022b) and in contexts such as faith-based investing (Criterion Institute, 2021). These resources demonstrate how investors can interrogate the intersectional nature of GLI through considering the role of geography in investment, such that gender is properly understood within the context of race, place, class, and ability (Criterion Institute, 2022a).

These and other intersectional frameworks represent ways in which some practitioners are already embracing the "new normal" for which we advocate and demonstrate how others might adopt an intersectional praxis within their own contexts. An intersectional approach to valuing gender diversity is not one with easy or universal solutions. It is an approach that requires organizations to examine their own practices, start listening to those they have excluded at each stage of the process, identify barriers to inclusion, deconstruct and dismantle those barriers, and re-establish goals for diversity that reflect the needs and interests of marginalized groups. Both future research and practice should examine strategies for including the voices of marginalized stakeholders in intersectional gender diversity management in order to deepen our field's understanding of *all* women in the workplace.

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